

the Halls

a story behind it," says Kumar. One of them is the legend of a temple in Bihar where worshippers are forbidden to worship after sunset in fear of Vvan Devi. Kapoor was fascinated when she heard Kumar's idea. So was *Panchayat* director Deepak Kumar Mishra. "Sometimes we ignore stories of our land, we don't believe in them but they are interesting to explore," says Mishra. "*Gaon ki sachchai* Panchayat *hai, gaon ki sachchai* folklore *bhi hai.*" With it Mishra fulfils his desire to tell stories in a different genre." My main inspiration is Steven Spielberg who creates varied emotions and never sticks to one genre," he adds.

In *Vvaan*, an urban man (Malhotra) juggling the fine line between superstition and belief heads to his hometown where he questions age-old beliefs but gradually finds answers he didn't foresee. The film unfolds over four days against the backdrop of Chhath Puja.

Early this year, TVF and Indusiverse released a comic book iteration of *Vvaan*, presenting a tale different from the film but setting up the legend. For the TVF audience Kumar promises a film which stays true to its ethos of "relatability" but given this time he is asking them to come to cinemas he also guarantees a "big screen sensibility". ■

—Suhani Singh

IN THE FILM, AN URBAN MAN **HEADS TO HIS HOMETOWN, SKEPTICAL OF ITS BELIEFS,** BUT FINDS UNEXPECTED TRUTHS



DOCUMENTARY ▼

Keeping the Faith

Bharatbala's short documentary on the Ramnamis of Chhattisgarh is an extraordinary tale of dignity and resilience

What happens when a community is ostracised merely because of caste? For the Ramnami community in Chhattisgarh, this was reality when they were denied entry into temples because of their social standing. However, its members retaliated with silent courage by tattooing the name of Ram across their bodies, turning an act of resistance into a powerful expression of faith.

It was this resilience that prompted acclaimed filmmaker Bharatbala to make *Ramnami*, a short film under the 'Virtual Bharat' series, which aims to tell 1,000 stories from across India. "Their faith did not need walls around it; they carried it wherever they went," says the director. "The story is about simple humanity, resilience, and the many ways in which we find dignity."



WHEN THEY WERE DENIED ENTRY TO A TEMPLE BECAUSE OF THEIR CASTE, THEY TATTOOED THE NAME OF RAM ON THEIR BODIES TO MARK RESISTANCE

The film went on to win the Rajat Kamal for Best Documentary at the 72nd National Film Awards recently, and Bharatbala believes that the honour belongs first to those who trusted him with their story. "To receive a National Award for *Ramnami* tells me that deeply local stories can have a much larger resonance. I hope the recognition takes more people back to the film, and through it, to the people whose lives made it possible."

Bharatbala is now working on *Mahasangam*, a feature on the Maha Kumbh Mela 2025. "Every time I think I know her, India surprises me with another story," he says. ■

—Deepa Natarajan Lobo